

Incredibly careful transmission

I will now evaluate the variants in the eleven ‘exceptional’ representatives.

MS 586 has one: 10:35— $\eta\mu\iota\nu$ || $\upsilon\mu\iota\nu$ 510,586. Since MS 510 has fourteen variants, and 586 never joins it elsewhere, there is evidently no dependency, so these are independent variants. But there is a curious aspect to this variant: it is nonsense! The sons of Zebedee say, “Teacher, we want you to do for us whatever we may ask”. So the variant, ‘to do for you (pl)’, is manifest nonsense. Was it a mere case of itacism? If so, it is the only one in the whole book (for 586). On several occasions, with different copyists in different books, I have observed a similar situation: the copyist has done perfect work to that point and then introduces an impossible variant, where the reader will almost automatically make the necessary correction, as here. It makes me wonder if the copyist felt unworthy to produce a perfect copy, and introduced an obvious error on purpose.

MS 2382 has one: 13:1— $\epsilon\iota\varsigma$ || $1 \epsilon\kappa$ 510, 1117, 2382. As with the example above, there is evidently no dependency, so these are independent variants. (MS 1117 has twelve variants.) “One of His disciples said to Him”—the preposition is implicit, and making it overt does not alter the meaning; the translation remains the same.

MS 2554 has two: 2:23— $\pi\omicron\iota\epsilon\iota\nu$ 2554^c || $\pi\iota\epsilon\iota\nu$ 1251, 2554, 2765; 15:46— $\epsilon\pi\iota$ την θύραν || 1 τη θύρα 2554 + eleven family representatives. The first one is manifest nonsense, independent instances of itacism. The copyist of 2554 caught his mistake and corrected it himself, so this is not a proper variant. The second one represents a split in the family. The preposition takes three cases—genitive, dative, accusative—so there is little difference in meaning.

MSS 789, 1072 and 2253 have three, to be discussed in that order. MS 789: 1:20— $\alpha\upsilon\tau\omega\nu$ || $\alpha\upsilon\tau\omicron\nu$ 789, 1199; 13:31— $\pi\alpha\rho\epsilon\lambda\epsilon\upsilon\sigma\epsilon\tau\alpha\iota$ || $\pi\alpha\rho\epsilon\lambda\epsilon\upsilon\sigma\omicron\nu\tau\alpha\iota$ [40%] 789 + twenty-one family representatives; 16:9— $\pi\rho\omega\tau\eta$ || $\pi\rho\omega\tau\omicron\nu$ 789. The first one is an independent itacism, resulting in nonsense. (MS 1199 has 73 variants.) The second one has already been explained in the first footnote, under “Copyist Care Quotient”. The third one is a silly mistake, where apparently the copyist became confused and assimilated the suffix to that of the following noun, only then it doesn’t make sense—perhaps he was hurrying to finish, being so near the end of the book. In any case, it is not a valid variant.

MS 1072: 6:22— $\omicron\rho\chi\eta\sigma\alpha\mu\epsilon\nu\eta\varsigma$ || $\omega\rho\chi\eta\sigma\alpha\mu\epsilon\nu\eta\varsigma$ 1072; 7:37— $\epsilon\zeta\epsilon\pi\lambda\eta\sigma\sigma\omicron\nu\tau\omicron$ || $\epsilon\zeta\epsilon\pi\lambda\eta\sigma\tau\omicron$ 1072; 9:20— $\iota\delta\omicron\nu$ || $\iota\delta\omega\nu$ [70%] 1072 +